5 Things to Check Before Winter Hits

Central Ohio winters swing between snow, ice, and thaw, sometimes in the same week. That's when gutters back up, filters clog, and pipes freeze. Here's the short list I'd give a neighbor in Hilliard, Dublin, Plain City, Upper Arlington, or anywhere in Columbus. Most of it takes an afternoon.

1 Gutters and downspouts: clear before the ice

- [ ] Wait until the last leaves are down, then scoop the gutters out. Wet leaves turn into a frozen dam once it gets cold.
- [ ] Run a hose down each downspout on a mild day. If the water backs up, there's a clog to clear before it freezes solid.
- [ ] Point every downspout at least 4 to 6 feet away from the house. Snowmelt dumped at the foundation ends up in the basement.
- [ ] Not comfortable on a ladder? Skip it and call a gutter company. A fall costs a lot more than a gutter cleaning.

2 Ice dams: watch the roof edge

- [ ] After a snow, look at the roof edge from the ground. A thick ridge of ice along the gutters, or big icicles, means heat is melting snow higher up and it's refreezing at the edge.
- [ ] Inside, look for water stains or peeling paint on ceilings and walls near outside walls, especially on the top floor.
- [ ] Don't chip at the ice or climb an icy roof. A roof rake from the ground can pull snow off the first few feet.
- [ ] Seeing stains or water dripping inside? Call a roofer. It usually points to an attic insulation or ventilation problem that's worth fixing before next winter.

3 Furnace filter: swap it now, then keep an eye on it

- [ ] Turn the thermostat off and slide out the old filter. The size is printed on the edge.
- [ ] Put the new one in with the airflow arrow pointing toward the furnace.
- [ ] Write the date on it. Most 1 inch filters need changing every 1 to 3 months when the heat is running, sooner with pets.

4 Smoke and CO alarms: test every one

- [ ] Press the test button on every alarm, on every floor. You want one on each level and outside the bedrooms.
- [ ] Look for the date on the back. Smoke alarms are good for about 10 years. CO alarms usually 7 to 10. Replace any that are past it.
- [ ] Swap batteries in anything that chirps. If a CO alarm goes off, get everyone outside and call 911.

5 If a pipe freezes

- [ ] Signs: you turn on a faucet and get nothing or a trickle, or you see frost on a pipe. Leave that faucet open.
- [ ] Warm the pipe slowly with a hair dryer, a heating pad, or warm towels, starting at the faucet end and working back. Never use an open flame.
- [ ] Find your main water shutoff now, before you need it. If a pipe splits, shut the main off first, then call.
- [ ] Call a plumber if you can't find the frozen spot, it's inside a wall, the pipe is cracked or leaking, or the water still isn't running after you've warmed it for a while.

WHILE YOU'RE AT IT

Close up drafty doors and windows with weatherstripping or a door sweep. Pull the hoses off the outside faucets and shut any crawl space vents. Have salt or ice melt and a shovel by the door before the first storm, not after.

Want a hand with any of this? I do quarterly home maintenance visits around Columbus: filters, smoke and CO alarm checks, sump checks, and a written Home Record after every visit. Call or text (614) 585-9814 or go to 1614home.co.

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General guidance for typical homes. If water is coming in, a pipe is leaking, or anything looks wrong, call a licensed pro.